had been a trending topic in Chinese social media and that authorities were actively censoring a particular hashtag—#WuhanReportedMysteriousPneumonia.[12] Reinforcing doubts was intel about a whistle-blower doctor in Wuhan, Dr Li Wenliang, later censored by the authorities, who had warned of a SARS-like virus after examining seven patients and advised doctors treating these patients to wear PPE (personal protective equipment) kits along with N95 masks. In fact, after raising the alarm, this doctor was summoned to the Chinese Public Security Bureau, where he was told to sign a letter which read, 'We solemnly warn you: if you keep being stubborn, with such impertinence, and continue this illegal activity, you will be brought to justice—is that understood?' Underneath the letter, Dr Li had signed in his handwriting, 'Yes I do'.[13] Thailand and Vietnam were the next two countries which seemed to have begun border screening Wuhan returnees.

Chatter had gotten louder about this mysterious pneumonia and had made its way to the prime minister through his personal network of individuals. He had alerted Dr Mishra in early January that he had heard about the pneumonia-like cases in China and that we should keep our guard up and track developments closely. This was not a new phenomenon at the PMO. The prime minister was more often than not ahead of the information going around. Over the years, he had meticulously developed a foolproof network to help him stay on top of things. People close to him say that he relies on four major sources: the first being the official network of government and Intelligence officers working at the PMO, the second, his colleagues and party workers from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the third, his Communications team and the fourth, his own personal network of relationships he has built with individuals over the years. He makes close to 50 calls per day at the minimum and it is this people-to-people connect which really helps him keep his ear on the ground, making him sensitive and reactive to even the smallest rumblings. In the meeting with Dr Mishra, he had also added that he would like to be briefed on what kinds of proactive measures India would be taking in order to tackle the outbreak, if it made its way to us. He particularly was of the opinion that it would be better to be overly responsive than underprepared and caught off guard in this situation. There was definite concern in the PMO that we were a country which had underdeveloped medical infrastructure; if a large-scale pandemic were to hit, India would have to make several upgrades and